

Monuments, Markers & Memorials (MMM)

Cataloging Methodology

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This document explains the classification system behind the MMM dataset — what’s included, what isn’t, and the decision rules used to keep those calls consistent across campuses and over time.

1. Category Domain

The `MMM_Category` coded-value domain has six values. Each is deliberately broad rather than narrowly specific, to avoid the kind of category sprawl that makes a domain unusable over time.

CODE	VALUE	COVERS
<code>MON</code>	Monument	Standalone commemorative structures (statues, obelisks, fountains) with no single named honoree
<code>MRK</code>	Marker	Text-bearing markers and plaques — historical, interpretive, dedicatory, or tradition-related — regardless of mount type
<code>MEM</code>	Memorial	Standalone commemorative objects or exhibits honoring one or more specifically named individuals
<code>MIL_EQ</code>	Military Equipment	Static ordnance and military equipment displays, reflecting UNG’s identity as a Senior Military College
<code>NM_BLDG</code>	Named Building/Space	Buildings, rooms, fields, and other spaces named for a person, family, or organization
<code>OTH</code>	Other	Genuine catch-all for items that don’t fit the above

Deliberate simplifications

Two early drafts of this domain were collapsed before finalizing, on the principle that a category should reflect *what a thing fundamentally is*, not incidental details about it:

- **Marker vs. Plaque** were merged into `MRK`. Whether a marker sits on a post or is bolted to a wall is a mounting detail, not a different kind of object — that distinction is captured separately in the `Mount` field (`FS` / `WM` / `GS`), not duplicated as a category split.
- **Monument vs. Statue** were merged into `MON`, for the same reason — a statue is a *form* of monument, not a separate category of thing.

2. Core Classification Rules

These are applied in order — the first rule that resolves the question determines the category.

Rule 1 — Is this naming a space, not a standalone object?

If a feature is naming or identifying a building, room, field, garden, or other space someone occupies or walks through, it is `NM_BLDG` **regardless of the wording on the plaque itself**. Several plaques literally say “memorial” while still describing a building naming, not a standalone commemorative object.

Precedent examples: Memorial Hall, the John L. Nix Mountain Cultural Center, the Newton Oakes Center, Ralston Hall, the Gainesville State College Wetland Pavilion, William J. Livsey Drill Field.

Rule 2 — For standalone objects: is there a specifically named honoree?

If a standalone commemorative object (not a space) honors one or more named individuals, it is `MEM`. If it does not — collective/institutional dedications, mascot dedications, class gifts, organizational donations — it is `MON` (for larger

standalone structures) or **MRK** (for text-bearing markers/plaques), depending on physical form.

MEM precedent: Dr. Louise C. Holcomb plaque, the John Alexander Howard memorial plaque, the Ruth L. Hoag memorial plaque, the Major General James E. Livingston Medal of Honor Plaza, the David E. Ralston Memorial Collection, the Dahlenega Memorial Wall (collective — honoring many named individuals as a group), the Gainesville Memorial and Remembrance Gardens.

MON / MRK precedent (no individual honoree): the sugar maple sesquicentennial marker, the College Arch (Class of 1951 gift), the Class of 1980 bench, the Omicron Delta Kappa “Nature Refuge” bench, the Pi Kappa Phi garden, the Phi Mu Fraternity bench, the Nighthawk mascot statue.

Rule 3 — Institutional donors are not the Honoree

A donor (a graduating class, a fraternity, a foundation, a board of regents) is credited in **Text / Notes**, never entered in **Honoree**. **Honoree** is reserved strictly for who a feature is *for*, not who paid for it. This distinction is what keeps Rule 2 workable — several markers have a clear donor but no honoree at all.

3. Field-Level Conventions

Honoree

- Plain names only — no titles, ranks, or honorifics (e.g., “James E. Livingston,” not “Maj. Gen. James E. Livingston (Ret.)”). Titles are preserved in **Text** instead. This keeps the field consistently matchable for queries like “show me everything tied to Livingston.”
- Joint dedications are written as “X and Y” (e.g., “Lynn and Mike Cottrell,” “Newton and Ella Ray Oakes”).
- Left blank for collective/institutional/donor-only dedications (see Rule 3).

Text

- Short plaques are transcribed verbatim in full.
- Lengthy interpretive panels** (multi-paragraph biographical content, such as the Nathan Deal Room or the Livingston Medal of Honor Plaza) are trimmed to the opening paragraph only. The full panel is preserved losslessly via the attached photograph, which the map’s lightbox lets a visitor zoom into and read in full — **Text** is a summary, not a substitute for the primary source.
- Very large name rosters** (the Dahlenega Memorial Wall’s 200+ names, a fraternity’s individually named brick walk) are not transcribed into **Text** at all. Where UNG already maintains an authoritative public roster (e.g., the official Memorial Wall page), the feature links out via **WebURL** instead of duplicating that data. Where no public source list yet exists, the feature is cataloged with a **Notes** flag to revisit once a roster becomes available.
- Plaque wording is transcribed **verbatim**, including unusual or non-standard phrasing (e.g., “In Memorial to” rather than “In Memory of”), rather than silently corrected to what a cataloger expects it to say.

Confidence

- 1** (Verified/Confirmed): Direct, legible transcription from a primary source.
- 0** (Unverified/Legacy Data): Any record where a detail is inferred rather than confirmed — a model identification based on visual silhouette rather than a data plate, an illegible line on a plaque, an uncertain link between a plaque and its physical location, or a circumstantial observation that hasn’t been confirmed against a named source.
- The specific gap is always stated in **Notes**, not just flagged — e.g., “chapter name illegible in available photo” rather than a bare confidence flag with no explanation.

Mount

Draws from the shared **MOUNTING_TYPE** coded-value domain (also used for access points elsewhere in the GIS program). MMM records use **FS** (Freestanding), **WM** (Wall-Mounted), or **GS** (Ground-Set) almost exclusively.

Status

ACT / **REM** / **REL** / **DMG** / **UR** / **PP** — describes the physical state of the object independently of how well-documented the record is (that’s what **Confidence** is for).

4. Structural Patterns for Complex Features

Several real cases didn’t fit a single plaque = single point model cleanly. These patterns keep the dataset consistent when they recur.

Multi-object exhibits are one point, not several

Where multiple objects form one cohesive tribute to a single subject — a portrait, a companion label, a commemorative rug, and a quote-wall installation, all honoring the same person — they are cataloged as **one** feature,

with each object entered as a photo in that feature's multi-image gallery, rather than split into separate points.

Example: the David E. Ralston Memorial Collection (portrait, biographical label, Speaker's rug, quote wall, memorabilia case) — one point, five photos.

Physically layered features are combined, not split

Where a historic marker has been physically incorporated into a larger structure and the two are experienced as one place, they are cataloged together.

Example: the College Arch (the 1951 arch itself, its 1995 freshman passageway, and the surrounding campus entrance brickwork) is one feature, not "the historic arch" separated from "the entrance sign."

Room-level naming: systematic donor programs vs. singular tributes

Individually named interior spaces (a donor-named classroom within a larger building) are **not** given their own MMM point by default — every room in a building collapsing onto the same coordinate defeats the purpose of a spatial layer. This is treated as a roster attached to the building's single point, not a separate feature.

The determining test is not simply "does a plaque exist" — several buildings plaque nearly every interior space as a matter of course, which would make that test meaningless. The real question is: **is this one exceptional commemorative act, or one instance of a repeatable donor-recognition program?**

Systematic donor-naming programs — multiple rooms or spaces within one building individually named for sponsors as part of an organized giving-recognition effort, comparable in mechanism to corporate stadium naming rights (e.g., Mercedes-Benz Stadium, T-Mobile Arena) — are documented as a roster attached to the building's single point, regardless of whether each room carries its own plaque and photo.

*Example: Wynne-Mathews Military Science Center and the Cottrell Center for Business, Technology & Innovation both name numerous individual rooms for donors as part of a systematic giving-recognition program. Each building is one **NM_BLDG** point; the individually named rooms are documented as an attached roster, not mapped as separate features.*

Singular tributes remain their own point. A room earns independent status only when it exists as a standalone commemorative act, not part of a repeatable naming program — typically evidenced by a full interpretive marker or panel (biography, photographs, substantive content) rather than a name plate alone.

*Example: the Nathan Deal Room at Young Hall — a full interpretive panel with biography and photographs, and not part of a systematic donor-naming program at that building — is its own **MEM** point.*

Buildings named after a benefactor, without further content, still get a point

A building whose only marker is a governance/construction credits plaque (governor, Board of Regents, architect, contractor — no individual dedication language) is still cataloged as **NM_BLDG**, with **Honoree** left blank, since the plaque doesn't single out one person to honor.

Example: the Blue Ridge Campus Academic Building (2020) and Ralston Hall's own dedication plaque, as distinct from the separate Ralston Memorial Collection exhibit housed inside it.

5. Evidentiary Standard

The dataset reports only what is verifiable, and states clearly when it isn't:

- Circumstantial evidence (fresh flowers, a heart shape formed in landscaping) is recorded as an *observation* in **Notes**, never promoted to a conclusion (e.g., "may serve as an informal memorial" rather than asserting it as one) unless a named honoree is actually confirmed.
- Where a detail is genuinely missing — an illegible line, an unconfirmed model, an unphotographed companion plaque — the record says so explicitly, with **Confidence = 0** and a specific note on what would resolve the gap.
- This standard is applied consistently even when it would be easy to assume more than what's actually shown.

6. Open Item

Public art: Purely decorative/non-dedicated campus art arguably falls outside MMM's scope — a related but separate cataloging effort — while dedicated or commemorative statuary remains in MMM under **MON**. No formal boundary has been finalized on this; it's flagged here as a known open question rather than a settled rule.

This methodology will continue to be applied as new sites are documented or reported. Questions on a specific classification call should reference the rule number above that governs it.